

Social Justice in the News

In September of 2024, Republican vice-presidential nominee and current vice president JD Vance took to social media platform X, previously Twitter, to falsely claim that Haitian immigrants in Springfield, Ohio were reported to be involved in abducting and eating household pets. This post sparked such an immediate backlash that multiple media sources responded by bringing awareness to the post and taking the time to reinforce that the claims were baseless and false. This was the case for Huo Jingnan and Jasmine Garsd's article *JD Vance spreads debunked claims about Haitian immigrants eating pets* that was published on the NPR website on September 10, 2024. Both writers speak to the inherent racism of the false claims and provide a brief history of the neo-Nazi origins of this specific conspiracy theory. The writers then go on to describe how these racist conspiracies have affected members of the Springfield, Ohio community. While the news articles that came out as a direct response to JD Vance's false claims speak to issues of racism that tinged the Republican party's presidential campaign, and the instances of misinformation and disinformation that accompanied this rhetoric along the way, there is a much deeper level that needs to be explored. Through an understanding of social justice scholarship, we can root deeper to understand the ways that misinformation and disinformation can insidiously be weaponized by those in power to continue the cycles of oppression and intersectionality based discrimination. Both can exist in a sort of feedback loop where one creates and feeds the other, further amplifying the other until we reach the stage of fully developed conspiracy theories that meet the light of day as we saw in JD Vance's post on X.

Chordia et al. (2024) introduces the concept of systems of power and discusses the ways that larger institutions can continuously reproduce injustice through the systems that they create and regularly interact with. These injustices are further shaped by the compounding effects of identity. Kimberle Crenshaw refers to this as the theory of intersectionality where "multiple marginalized identifies experience oppression as an additive, compounding phenomenon rather than a singular, disconnected phenomenon" (Chordia et al., 2024, pp. 3). Morgan expands on this idea by developing the Axes of Oppression to provide a visual representation of the ways that both privilege and oppression can affect people at the individual and community levels depending on where they fall within the axes (Chordia et al., 2024). Tsatsou (2022) further explores this concept of intersectionality by looking at the ways that it directly affects users in the digital realm. While technology can be beneficial in its endeavors to provide ease of access to information for various communities, research has found that the experiences of those

that use technology are not devoid of the ways that systems of power and oppression have embedded themselves in other institutions. Technology and digital systems have the power to “reproduce, strengthen or resist pre-existing power relationships and the associated social inequalities” (Tsatsou, 2022, pp. 1479). Both of these scholarly works shed light on the way that the intersecting identities of nationality, race, and culture have compounded in a very specific way that has affected the experiences of the Haitian community in Springfield, Ohio. The racist ideology prevalent amongst white supremacists of the area, and the labeling of the Haitian community as immigrant and therefore ‘other’ has made them the target of erroneous conspiracy theories that affirm and amplify the fearmongering and talking points of Donald Trump’s political strategy and have left this Haitian community vulnerable to the tactics used to scapegoat a community in the effort to advance political ideology. This rhetoric of the immigrant as criminal and negative for the nation is nothing new to the Trump administration (Jingnan and Garsd, 2024).

While it can be easy to focus on the way that the intersectionality of race, nationality, and culture have affected the Haitian community of Springfield and been used to advance racist rhetoric at the national level, it would be a disservice to not also focus on the ways that misinformation and disinformation work hand in hand to strengthen and advance the racist rhetoric used by JD Vance in the hope of creating political sway. Fallis describes disinformation as “misleading information that has the function of misleading someone” (2015, pp. 413). This emphasis on the function for misleading people should be noted as it is what separates disinformation from misinformation which is described as inaccurate information that is not necessarily intentional. Disinformation is especially insidious because it was created and distributed with the intention of misleading and creating harm (Fallis, 2015). O’Connor discusses the way that misinformation and disinformation have historically existed in relation to the concept of truth and power. Government entities use their positions of power to peddle their own philosophies and lean on their positions to provide a sense of authority and authenticity to the information that they are pushing out to the general public. These ‘truths’ are shaped by cultural and political factors and are motivated by the informer’s intentions. Governments and those in power then lean on their positions to legitimize their narratives of truth to create sway among the masses (O’Connor, 2022). This can be especially dangerous when those in power use the legitimacy associated with their title to purposefully push intentionally misleading information as was the case with JD Vance using his platform to blatantly spread bigoted white supremacist ideology on the national stage. He, as the vice presidential candidate, was weaponizing the perceived credibility of his position and platform to legitimize ideology recognized as false that intended to create fear by pushing a

tale that capitalized on a nation's lack of understanding, and sometimes outright loathe for a community shaped by nationality, culture, and race whose identity is often used in talking points of what it means to belong in America.

Nunberg speaks to the ways that the invention of the internet has led to the ability for misinformation and disinformation to bypass the previous eras of needing media involvement to spread misleading information. "The internet clearly amplifies those tendencies by eliminating constraints on the production and diffusion of information" (Nunberg, 2021, pp. 501). The white supremacist rhetoric which pre-internet relied on dissemination through the often hidden practice of passing out literature, now no longer needs to rely on these in-person encounters. Ideology can be quickly and widely disseminated online under the cloak of anonymity if need be. It then gets cycled through various sectors of the internet, possibly gaining legitimacy along the way depending on who chooses to share it. This was the case with JD Vance's post about the Haitian community. Elon Musk, the owner of X, used his platform to amplify this false claim to his nearly 200 million followers on the platform (Jingnan and Garsd, 2024). This conspiracy theory, that had once been relegated to the dark corners of the neo-Nazi sector of the internet was now center stage in the months leading up to a national election being used as an obvious tactic to garner favor amongst members of a certain political belief, and scare others into voting a certain way.

While Jingnan and Garsd's (2024) article draws attention to JD Vance's racist post on X, aimed at spreading the Neo Nazi created conspiracy theory that members of the Haitian community of Springfield, Ohio were eating pets, the news piece itself highlights the underlying social justice topics of intersectionality based oppression, and disinformation. More specifically it speaks to the ways that discrimination based on intersectional identity and disinformation often go hand in hand, both structures created and spread by those in power, and interwoven in a way that feed off and amplify each other to spread whatever philosophy or version of truth those in power have created to help keep themselves in power.

References

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